



OFF-SIDE

Ayon Sengupta

sportstar@thehindu.co.in



THE SHARED LANGUAGE OF SPORT

You might watch a match alone on your phone, **yet feel part of** something vast.

There are few joys as profound as watching sport. Not playing it, not even fully comprehending it at times, but simply watching it unfold. It may seem, at first glance, a passive act. Yet it seldom feels that way.

Because sport does something remarkable. It draws you in.

A last-minute goal is more than a goal. It's a collective gasp in a living room, a stadium rising in one motion, strangers turning into co-conspirators in joy. For a few seconds, geography dissolves. Language becomes irrelevant. Ecstasy and despair need no translation.

That is where the real joy lies, not simply in the spectacle, but in the sharing of it.

We often speak about sport as entertainment, as content, as a product. But these are modern labels trying to contain something far older, far more instinctive. Watching sport is a ritual. It is an inheritance. It is the closest many of us come to belonging.

You might watch a match alone on your phone, yet feel part of something vast. You know that somewhere, thousands, sometimes millions, if the Men in Blue or the Albiceleste are playing, feel the same tension, the same hope, the same irrational belief in a comeback.

The teams we support are rarely chosen with logic. They are inherited, absorbed, or stumbled upon. A city, a player, a moment in childhood. And before we realise it, their victories begin to feel like our own, their failures uncomfortably

personal.

This is the strange contract sport offers: emotional investment without tangible return. And yet, it never feels like a loss.

Over time, these fragments of skill, memory, and shared experience begin to shape us. They teach us how to wait, how to endure, how to celebrate without restraint, and how to lose gracefully. They give us stories we carry, references we return to, conversations we never quite finish.

In an increasingly fragmented world, sport remains one of the last shared languages.

You don't always remember the score. But you remember where you were. Who you were with. How it felt.

And somewhere between a Roger Federer backhand or a Sachin Tendulkar cover drive, between Virat Kohli's aggression and Lionel Messi's elegance, between Novak Djokovic's control and Mike Tyson's chaos, we find the reason we keep watching.

We don't watch them to become them. We watch them because, in fragments, they resemble us, our patience, our rage, our longing to get it right just once.

Every generation picks its own references, but the grammar remains the same. Federer teaches us that grace can be decisive. Tendulkar, that beauty can be disciplined. Kohli, that intensity can be a language. Ronaldo and Djokovic, that obsession can be a craft.

We watch sport not for the result, but for everything that stays with us long after it is over.